

PALACE OF FINE ARTS

A Love Story

FADE IN:

1 EXT. PALACE OF FINE ARTS - ROTUNDA - DAY

Late afternoon light filters through the columns, casting long shadows across the lagoon. A handful of tourists mill about, taking photos.

MAYA CHEN (32), petite with paint-stained fingers she hasn't bothered to clean, sits cross-legged on the grass with a worn sketchbook. Her dark hair escapes a messy bun. She draws with intense focus, oblivious to the world.

DANIEL OKAFOR (35), tall and broad-shouldered in a well-fitted blazer that suggests he came straight from work, walks slowly along the colonnade. He holds his phone but isn't looking at it. There's a heaviness to him -- a man trying to outpace his own thoughts.

He stops near one of the massive columns, tilts his head back, stares up at the weeping women carved into the stone.

DANIEL

(quietly, to himself)

Cheerful.

MAYA (O.S.)

They're mourning the death of art.

Daniel turns. Maya hasn't looked up from her sketchbook.

DANIEL

Sorry?

MAYA

The figures. Bernard Maybeck designed this whole place to feel

melancholy. It was supposed to be temporary. A beautiful ruin.

DANIEL

And yet here it is. A hundred years later.

Maya finally looks up. Studies him with an artist's eye.

MAYA

You don't look like a tourist.

DANIEL

I'm not. I work three blocks from here. I just never...

He trails off. Shrugs.

MAYA

Never stopped.

DANIEL

Yeah.

A beat. Maya returns to her sketch.

DANIEL (CONT'D)

What are you drawing?

MAYA

Wouldn't you like to know.

She says it flatly, but there's a hint of a smile.

2 EXT. PALACE OF FINE ARTS - LAGOON EDGE - CONTINUOUS

Daniel walks closer, maintaining a respectful distance. Maya doesn't stop drawing but shifts slightly -- making room.

DANIEL

I'm Daniel.

MAYA

Maya.

He sits on the grass a few feet away. Loosens his tie.

DANIEL

I just sat through a four-hour meeting about quarterly projections. Do you know what a quarterly projection is?

MAYA

A guess in a spreadsheet?

DANIEL

(laughing)

That's exactly what it is.

He looks out at the water. Swans glide past, indifferent.

DANIEL (CONT'D)

I used to want to be an architect.

MAYA

What happened?

DANIEL

Business school. Student loans. The usual story of American practicality defeating American dreams.

MAYA

That's depressing.

DANIEL

It pays well.

MAYA

Still depressing.

She holds up her sketchbook, shows him. It's the rotunda, but abstract -- all fractured lines and shadow.

MAYA (CONT'D)

I make about twelve dollars an hour teaching drawing to retirees at the community center.

DANIEL

Happy?

Maya considers this seriously.

MAYA

Most days. Today's been good.
You?

DANIEL

Today's getting better.

3 EXT. PALACE OF FINE ARTS - COLONNADE - LATER

They walk together now through the massive columns. The light has shifted to gold. Maya's sketchbook is tucked under her arm.

MAYA

Okay, worst first date. Go.

DANIEL

We're doing this?

MAYA

I'm nosy. It's a character flaw.

DANIEL

She spent two hours showing me her ex-boyfriend's Instagram. Kept saying "I'm so over him" while zooming in on his abs.

MAYA

Oh no.

DANIEL

She cried in the Uber.

MAYA

(laughing)

Mine brought his mother.

DANIEL

What?

MAYA

She had opinions about my posture.

DANIEL

Please tell me you left.

MAYA

I have excellent posture now.

They share a look. Something shifts between them -- easier now.

DANIEL

So the retirees. What do they draw?

MAYA

Fruit, mostly. Marge is working on a bowl of lemons that's going to take her the rest of her life.

DANIEL

You love it.

MAYA

(caught off guard)

I do. Is that pathetic?

DANIEL

It's the least pathetic thing I've heard all week.

4 EXT. PALACE OF FINE ARTS - BENCH BY THE WATER - DUSK

They sit on a bench facing the lagoon. The palace glows pink in the fading light. Maya hugs her knees to her chest.

MAYA

Why today?

DANIEL

What do you mean?

MAYA

You said you work three blocks away. Years, I'm guessing. Why'd you finally stop today?

Daniel is quiet for a long moment. He pulls out his phone, looks at it, puts it away.

DANIEL

My dad called this morning. Told me he has Parkinson's.

MAYA

Daniel.

DANIEL

He sounded so... matter-of-fact about it. Like he was giving me a weather report.

Maya doesn't offer platitudes. She just listens.

DANIEL (CONT'D)

I sat in that meeting about projections and profit margins and I thought -- what am I doing? What am I actually doing?

MAYA

So you went for a walk.

DANIEL

So I went for a walk.

A swan drifts past. Maya pulls a pencil from behind her ear.

MAYA

Can I tell you something?

DANIEL

Yeah.

MAYA

I come here every Tuesday. For three years. You're the first person who's actually talked to me.

DANIEL

People don't talk to you?

MAYA

I give off a vibe. Apparently.

She gestures at herself -- the paint stains, the messy hair, the slight frown that seems to be her resting face.

DANIEL

I like the vibe.

5 EXT. PALACE OF FINE ARTS - PATHWAY - NIGHT

String lights have come on around the colonnade. Maya and Daniel walk slowly toward the exit. Neither seems to want to leave.

MAYA

I don't have a phone.

DANIEL

What?

MAYA

I mean, I have a phone. It's at home. In a drawer. I check it once a day. It's a whole thing.

DANIEL

That's either very healthy or completely insane.

MAYA

Little of both.

Daniel laughs. Runs a hand over his head.

DANIEL

So how do I...

MAYA

I'll be here. Next Tuesday. Same bench.

DANIEL

That's very analog of you.

MAYA

I'm a very analog person.

They've reached the edge of the park. The city hums beyond them.

DANIEL

Maya.

MAYA

Yeah?

DANIEL

Thank you. For talking to me. I know that sounds--

MAYA

It doesn't sound anything. I'm glad you stopped.

She offers her hand. He takes it. It's not quite a handshake -- they hold on a moment too long.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Go call your dad.

DANIEL

Yeah.

She walks away. Ten feet. Stops. Turns.

MAYA

Daniel?

He's still watching her.

MAYA (CONT'D)

It's supposed to rain next
Tuesday.

DANIEL

I'll bring an umbrella.

She smiles -- a real one -- and disappears into the San Francisco night.

6 EXT. PALACE OF FINE ARTS - BENCH BY THE WATER - DAY

One week later. Rain mists over the lagoon. The palace looks like a watercolor painting, blurred at the edges.

Maya sits on the same bench, hood up, sketchbook protected under her jacket.

She's alone.

She looks at her watch. Looks at the empty path. Something flickers across her face -- disappointment she's trying not to feel.

Then -- footsteps. Running.

Daniel appears, slightly out of breath, carrying an umbrella he hasn't opened. He's soaking wet.

DANIEL

The umbrella broke.

MAYA

(trying not to smile)

I see that.

He sits down next to her. Water drips from his hair.

DANIEL

I called my dad.

MAYA

Yeah?

DANIEL

We talked for three hours. I don't think we've talked for three hours total in the last ten years.

Maya nods. She pulls a folded paper from her sketchbook. Hands it to him.

MAYA

I made you something.

Daniel unfolds it carefully, protecting it from the rain. It's a drawing of the colonnade -- but in the corner, barely visible, two figures sit on the grass.

DANIEL

(quietly)

Maya.

MAYA

It's probably weird. It's weird. Forget it--

He kisses her. Soft. Brief. They pull apart.

DANIEL

Tuesday works for me.

MAYA

Yeah?

DANIEL

Every Tuesday. For however long you'll have me.

Maya takes his hand. They sit together in the rain, watching the swans, as the ancient ruin of a building holds them like a secret.

FADE OUT.